Gmail

# IEEE Access - Decision on Manuscript ID Access-2026-40729

On Tue, Sep 29, 2026 at 4:28 PM IEEE Access <onbehalfof@manuscriptcentral.com> wrote:
29-Sep-2026

Dear Dr. Arafat:

I am writing to you regarding manuscript # Access-2026-40729 entitled "Comments on “E-Voting Meets Blockchain: A Survey”" which you submitted to IEEE *Access*.

In view of the criticisms of the reviewers found at the bottom of this letter, your manuscript has not been recommended for publication in IEEE *Access*. Unfortunately, we will not accept resubmissions of this article.

Thank you for considering IEEE *Access* for the publication of your research.

Sincerely,

Dr. Jenny Mahoney
Associate Editor, IEEE *Access*
ieeeaccess2@ieee.org

Reviewers' Comments to Author:

Reviewer: 1

Comments:
Many of the claims the author made are exaggerated and not found in the original survey. The citations used didn't not support the claims. This is an opinion piece without valid scientific literature support. The original survey made no claim of national-level election as the author claimed. The author also confirmed that online voting is sometimes used by private entities and political parties. The author’s lack of understanding that e-voting refers only to national-level elections creates a biased view of peer-reviewed publication. Therefore, the claims made in the comment piece were not grounded in a broad range of literature and were not substantiated. The opinion of the author in this comment was not grounded or supported by facts and the existing literature.

Additional Questions:
Please confirm that you have reviewed all relevant files, including supplementary files and any author response files, which can be found in the "View Author's Response" link above (author responses will only appear for resubmissions): Yes, all files have been reviewed

1) Does the paper contribute to the body of knowledge?: This paper is comments on a survey paper titled "E-voting Meets Blockchain: A Survey." The comments present a bias point of view from the author that does not contribute to the body of knowledge.

2) Is the paper technically sound?: The paper is not technically sound with incomplete citations and used github and unverified sources to support the author's point of view.

3) Is the subject matter presented in a comprehensive manner?: This is an opinion piece that discuss one single survey paper from the author's point of view with no comprehensive analysis of current literature.

4) Are the references provided applicable and sufficient?: The paper has incomplete references, github links with no discussion of how the content supports the author's claim.

5) Are there references that are not appropriate for the topic being discussed?: Yes

5a) If yes, then please indicate which references should be removed.: The author uses non-peer reviewed references (opinions, websites), unverified citations [10] (a researchgate link provided but conference proceeding did not show any record of the acceptance of this paper presented at the conference) and sources published after the commented survey was published.

Reviewer: 2

Comments:
I have read the document and claims made and compared with what is written about on the original review paper and found that they do not match in the great majority. Although that is enough to dismiss the claim, and so the Comment paper, I checked the references as evidence supporting the claim, and I could not find evidence that support the claims as some papers are white paper, or non peer-reviewed, or opinion documents, and one of the references didn't appear in the proceedings of the conferences it was claimed to be. One reference was a book that didn't mention what is was claimed, and finally some github references just made no sense to consider. Therefore, I think this is a frivolous paper with frivolous evidence and it should not be considered as a serious manuscript.

It should be noted by the author of the Comment manuscript that the original review paper is not an opinion paper so it is not on favor or against using blockchain technology on e-voting but it does introduce the technology and the concepts that blockchain uses. In fact, the review paper is useful to educate people about blockchain, so people can be better informed and make better decisions.

Additional Questions:
Please confirm that you have reviewed all relevant files, including supplementary files and any author response files, which can be found in the "View Author's Response" link above (author responses will only appear for resubmissions): Yes, all files have been reviewed

1) Does the paper contribute to the body of knowledge?: No, no new information is provided in the paper.

2) Is the paper technically sound?: No, the paper claims are unsubstantiated.

3) Is the subject matter presented in a comprehensive manner?: No, the comments are poorly organized and expressed, and also not supported.

4) Are the references provided applicable and sufficient?: Most references provided are not supporting the claims or are opinion documents.

5) Are there references that are not appropriate for the topic being discussed?: Yes

5a) If yes, then please indicate which references should be removed.: Most references are not acceptable. Many are opinions without proof, other are not peer reviewed, and one of them is not in the conference proceedings it claimed to be. We do not accept Researchgate paper as anybody can upload that.

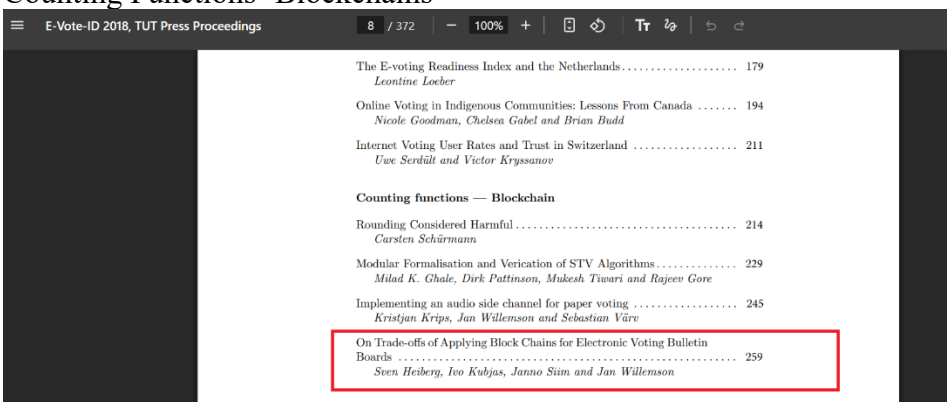
If you have any questions, please contact article administrator: Mrs. Kimberly Rybczynski k.rybczynski@ieee.org

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On Tue, Sep 29, 2026 at 7:27 PM DrShymaa Arafat <shar.academic@gmail.com> wrote:

I have a rebuttal statement:

*First for both reviewers:
**1-Reference [10] is a peer-reviewed paper**, but it is free and easily downloadable from Researchgate. Not all E-Vote-ID accepted papers get selected for publication on Springer LNCS (only 13 of about 29 accepted). The reviewers can check the official E-Vote-ID site (https://www.e-vote-id.org/proceedings/) under the year 2018 press on TUT press proceedings which will lead you to (https://digikogu.taltech.ee/et/Item/0050d4bb-192b-4531-8e23-ccf8b565222e) press on the PDF link and download it, you will find the paper on page 259 under Counting Functions -Blockchains



S. Heiberg, I. Kubjas, J. Siim and J. Willemson, “On Trade-offs of Applying Blockchains for Electronic Voting Bulletin Boards”, E-Vote ID 2018, Austria, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/326450103_On_Trade offs_of_Applying_Block_Chains_for_Electronic_Voting_Bulletin_B oards; last accessed 12/8/2026.

**2-The white paper and the application site are the most credible source of a commercial application as it is written by the researchers & developers who designed it. (Agora** case, **Polyas** case)

3- **The included Githubs in [13,16] are the official governmental ones** of the open source code used in their e-voting systems; those were added for anyone (especially the reviewers) who wants to trace the used code to make sure it does not use blockchains.

*For Reviewer 1:

1-The authors put those claims under **A. Systems Used By Government Institutions** and I think I wrote some examples that would not be wrong to include under **B.Commercial Blockchain Based E-Voting Systems**, but not accurate to put in A.

2-Polyas, Germany, and Estonia cases are crystal clear wrong published info, and I showed an example of a law peer-reviewed paper that was misguided because of that.(ref. [22]); by the way I've contacted its authors and they have appreciated my effort and contacted their journal to edit their paper ("to keep the integrity of the academic record" in their own words).

*For Reviewer 2:

1-I did not request to retract the original paper to defend its added value to research, I'm correcting some factual errors on it; otherwise you should be held responsible for the propagation of wrong/inaccurate information (ex. ref. [22] in my comment).

2-Please mention the book reference you say does not mention what is claimed.

Please deliver my rebuttal statement to the reviewers and tell me what is the official path to submit it.

Thanks,
Shymaa M. Arafat,
Associate Professor CS/CE (Independent)

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**DrShymaa Arafat <shar.academic@gmail.com>** Thu, Oct 1, 9:32 AM (2 days ago)

to j.mahoney, Kim, ieeeaccesseic, Logan, shymaa

A final note to all the editorial board of IEEE Access,

When Reviewer1 says:

*"The author’s lack of understanding that e-voting refers only to national-level elections creates a biased view of peer-reviewed publication."*

Now, consider this specific statement from the abstract of the paper I was commenting on:

*" This technology has been adopted by countries such as Germany, Russia, Estonia, and Switzerland for use in their e-voting systems. "*

Does it refer to any e-voting system or to National-level elections????

Among all the mentioned countries, only Russia deploys blockchains in their national-level e-voting system.

The South Korean government uses blockchain e-voting in governmental institutions but not in national level elections. However, it is not South Korea that appears in this sentence.

Put it plain and simple:

**If Germany, Estonia, and Switzerland do not use blockchains in their national-level elections e-voting system, are you or are you not spreading wrong information?**

How come expert reviewers in the e-voting research area do not know that?or consider the official GitHub of the governmental open source code of their e-voting system a credible reference?

How come expert reviewers in the blockchain research area do not consider the white paper made by the product designers and developers a credible reference?

There is something wrong here, please fix it and set the record straight.

Thanks,

Shymaa M. Arafat
Associate Professor in Computer Science
(PhD in Computer Science & Systems Engineering)
ORCID:0009-0009-7571-4060, IEEE(CS): 102400508
(Independent)